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REVIEW PAPER

Unethical Pro-organizational Behavior: A Systematic Review and Future Research Agenda

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Abstract
Since the conceptualization of *unethical pro-organizational behavior* ten years ago, scholarly interest in exploring this phenomenon has multiplied. Given a burgeoning body of empirical research, a review of unethical pro-organizational behavior literature is warranted. This study, therefore, systematically reviews the extant literature on unethical pro-organizational behavior and presents a comprehensive theory-based review of the past developments in this field. We classify previous studies based on their underlying theoretical perspectives and discuss the antecedents and consequences of unethical pro-organizational behavior in work context. We also explicate the boundary conditions under which the influence of these antecedents gets accentuated or alleviated. Overall, this study synthesizes past knowledge to elucidate why, how, and when unethical pro-organizational behavior unfolds in the workplace. Finally, the gaps in the extant theorization are identified and an agenda for future research is proposed.

Keywords Unethical pro-organizational behavior (UPOB) · Systematic literature review · Future research agenda

Introduction

The exponential rise of corporate scandals across the globe has taken the entire business landscape by a storm. According to the *Financial Cost of Fraud report* published in 2019, the total cost that corporates incur for fraud sums up to more than $5 trillion per annum globally (Gee and Button 2019). To discourage businesses from behaving unethically, regulatory bodies around the world have established stringent corporate governance standards. Still, employees continue to participate in fraudulent activities, so much so that even industry giants have to lose billions of dollars in the form of fines and settlements for their employees' ethical lapses. In response to this pressing moral and financial concern, a sizeable volume of scholarly research has been conducted thus far to assist practitioners and policymakers in curbing the menace of unethical employee behavior in the workplace.

Notwithstanding the abundance of research surrounding employee misconduct, we note that a significant proportion of this research has predominantly viewed unethical behavior as 'purely' self-serving. Academics have largely avowed that employees participate in unethical activities only to satisfy their selfish interests (Seuntjens et al. 2019), harm rivals (Kilduff et al. 2016), or retaliate against the organization (Cohen et al. 2013). However, in practical settings, employees can also be seen participating in unethical activities to benefit entities external to themselves, such as the organization or its members. For instance, a senior production executive at Volkswagen recently developed 'defeat devices' to help his organization circumvent fuel-emission tests (Fortune 2018). Such employee behaviors toward benefiting the organization were nowhere recognized in the mainstream academic literature until Umphress et al. (2010) advanced that employees may also behave unethically to benefit their organizations—*unethical pro-organizational behavior*. It is

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noteworthy that despite the positive intention behind unethical pro-organizational behaviors, they may result in perilous outcomes for the participating individuals as well as their organizations. For instance, the executive at Volkswagen developed defeat devices to benefit his organization. However, his action instead ended up harming him (sentenced to seven years in prison) as well as his organization, with Volkswagen paying over $45 billion worldwide in fines, buybacks, and refits (The Guardian 2019).

Unethical pro-organizational behavior has been theorized as a set of actions that are unethical, but seek to further the interests of the organization or its agents (Umphress et al. 2010). Since this conceptualization nearly ten years ago, behavioral ethics scholars have exhibited increasing interest in exploring this phenomenon at length. Several studies have delved into the individual, supervisor, and organizational-level factors, and their ensuing psychological processes that precipitate the incidence of unethical pro-organizational behavior in the workplace. Researchers have also shed light on the contingency variables that aggravate or attenuate the effect of these antecedents on unethical pro-organizational behavior. Given the considerable body of empirical research that has accumulated in this domain, a review of the unethical pro-organizational behavior literature is warranted to take stock of the extant theorization and highlight unexplored opportunities for further development. We, therefore, conduct a systematic review of the current body of knowledge on unethical pro-organizational behavior.

Our study makes two-fold contribution to the academic literature on organizational behavior. First, we synthesize unethical pro-organizational behavior research conducted over the past ten years using a theory-based approach. In doing so, we develop a comprehensive framework that meaningfully organizes extant research into three areas of emphasis, namely, *antecedents*, *consequences*, and *boundary conditions*. This study is of immediate relevance to scholars as it would enable them to assimilate the existing body of unethical pro-organizational behavior research from a theoretical standpoint and gain an understanding of how the concept has evolved. Second, we present a detailed research agenda and identify several avenues for future research. The research agenda also contributes to the unethical pro-organizational behavior literature by identifying new possibilities for exploration and stimulating scholarly interest to develop this domain of work further.

The rest of this paper is structured as follows. First, we begin with the conceptual distinction between unethical pro-organizational behavior and other related constructs in the literature. Doing so is necessary to clarify where unethical pro-organizational behavior is situated in the landscape of business ethics concepts, and why it warrants scholarly as well as managerial attention as a separate construct. Next, we explicate the method adopted for conducting the systematic review, within which we state the inclusion and exclusion criteria and the literature search process. Further, we put forth different theoretical perspectives that have been used by scholars to explain the precursors of unethical pro-organizational behavior in the workplace. Under each theoretical perspective, we discuss the studies that have drawn on that perspective to support their arguments related to unethical pro-organizational behavior. Likewise, we deliberate over the boundary conditions and consequences using a theory-based approach. We conclude by highlighting gaps in the current knowledge, and proposing an agenda for future research.

Distinguishing Unethical Pro-organizational Behavior from Related Constructs

The construct of unethical pro-organizational behavior (hereafter, UPOB) is grounded in the seminal work of Umphress and Bingham (2011). They defined it as "actions that are intended to promote the effective functioning of the organization or its members (e.g., leaders) and violate core societal values, mores, laws, or standards of proper conduct" (p. 622). Two components are fundamental to this conceptualization of UPOB. First, UPOB is *unethical* because it violates 'hypernorms' or "globally held standards of ethical behavior judged in terms of justice, law, or widely held social norms" (Umphress and Bingham 2011, p. 622; Donaldson and Dunfee 1994). Unethicality is determined based on hypernorms, and employee ehavior is regarded as unethical if it violates absolute societal standards, i.e., hypernorms, rather than local benchmarks such as organizational norms (Umphress and Bingham 2011). Second, UPOB is *pro-organizational behavior* because neither is it instructed by supervisors nor stated in formal job descriptions, yet performed voluntarily with the aim of benefiting or helping the organization and (or) its members (Umphress et al. 2010; Umphress and Bingham011). UPOB encompasses acts of omission (e.g., concealing negative information about the organization and its products/services) as well as commission (e.g., propagating false positive information about the organization and its products/services) (Umphress et al. 2010; Umphress and Bingham 2011).

The aforementioned conceptualization of UPOB stands close to a few other competing concepts in the field of organizational behavior. However, as there are crucial distinctions between UPOB and these theoretically similar concepts, UPOB warrants scholarly as well as managerial attention as a separate construct. In what follows, we delineate the key similarities as well as distinctions between UPOB and other related behaviors.

Necessary Evils

Necessary evil refers to "a work-related task in which an individual must, as part of his or her job, perform an act that causes emotional or physical harm to another human being in the service of achieving some perceived greater good or purpose" (Molinsky and Margolis 2005, p. 247). Examples of necessary evils include healthcare workers performing physically painful procedures on their patients, teachers giving negative feedback to their students, managers delivering bad news, among others (Molinsky and Margolis 2005). The point of similarity between necessary evils and UPOB is that both of these behaviors may be carried out to benefit the organization. However, necessary evils are distinct from UPOB in the following ways. First, while UPOB is carried out to mainly benefit the organization, necessary evil is a broader concept because the acts covered under necessary evils may also benefit the society at large (Umphress and Bingham 2011). Second, UPOB consists of unethical behaviors, whereas necessary evils comprise of ethical behaviors (Umphress and Bingham 2011). Third, UPOB is a voluntary behavior that is not specified in the formal job descriptions and is performed by employees at their discretion. However, necessary evils include tasks that employees are obligated to undertake as a part of the requirements of their professional positions. Thus, an employee bribing officials to help the organization win a contract (UPOB) is only serving the organization's interest and violating hypernorms. Accordingly, such behaviors though pro-organizational still remain unethical and cannot be classified under necessary evils.

Organizational Misbehavior

Vardi and Wiener (1996) defined organizational misbehavior as "any intentional action by members of organizations that violates core organizational and/or societal norms" (p. 151). Organizational misbehavior encompasses three types of acts—(a) acts that are consistent with societal norms but violate organizational standards (e.g., whistleblowing), (b) acts that are consistent with organizational standards but violate societal norms (e.g., misleading customers), and (c) acts that violate both societal and organizational norms (e.g., unauthorized use of company property) (Vardi and Wiener 1996). UPOB, however, only includes acts that violate societal norms, regardless of whether they violate or are consistent with organizational expectations (e.g., overcharging clients regardless of whether the organization appreciates or condemns such behavior) (Umphress and Bingham 2011). Thus, UPOB can be safely considered as a subset of the overall organizational misbehavior concept.

Deviance

Warren (2003) proposed a typology of employee deviance along two dimensions—whether the behavior deviates from or conforms to (a) globally held beliefs or values (i.e., hypernorms) and (b) reference group norms (i.e., organizational norms). Accordingly, Warren (2003) postulated that employee work behaviors might be classified into four broad categories, namely, *constructive conformity*, *destructive conformity*, *constructive deviance*, and *destructive deviance*. We now discuss the points of differentiation between UPOB and each of these behaviors. *Constructive conformity* refers to "behavior that falls within both sets of norms" (Warren 2003, p. 628). UPOB is an intersecting concept because it can conform to organizational norms. However, it surely violates hypernorms. *Destructive conformity* refers to "behavior that falls within reference group norms but deviates from hypernorms" (Warren 2003, p. 628). Both destructive conformity and UPOB violate hypernorms. However, destructive conformity surely conforms to organizational norms, whereas UPOB may or may not do so. For example, an organization may have strict rules against the sale of expired products, but employees may anyway sell expired products to protect their companies from financial loss. Such behavior can be termed as UPOB but would fail to qualify as destructive conformity because it violates organizational norms.

Constructive deviance refers to "behavior that deviates from the reference group norms but conforms to hypernorms" (Warren 2003, p. 628). Examples of constructive deviance include whistleblowing and prosocial rule-breaking (Vadera et al. 2013). While constructive deviance conforms to hypernorms, UPOB violates them. However, constructive deviance can be considered as a partly intersecting concept because it violates organizational norms, which UPOB may or may not break. *Destructive deviance* refers to "behavior that falls outside both sets of norms (reference group and hypernorms)" (Warren 2003, p. 628). An example of destructive deviance is embezzlement. Both UPOB and destructive deviance violate hypernorms. However, destructive deviance violates organizational norms, whereas UPOB may violate or be consistent with organizational expectations. For example, an organization may have a toxic culture wherein the exploitation of employees for organizational welfare is condoned. Underpaying subordinates and yelling at them to fulfill the organization's interests conforms to the organizational norms, but violates the hypernorms of interpersonal respect and justice. Hence, such behavior can be termed as UPOB, but would fail to qualify as destructive deviance.

Pro-self Unethical Behavior and Unethical Decision-Making

Pro-self unethical behavior refers to unethical activities that employees carry out to solely benefit themselves (Thau et al. 2015). There are other theoretically similar concepts in the literature, such as unethical decision-making. An unethical decision refers to "an intention, perception, or behavior that is morally unacceptable by societal standards" and "includes misuses of position, resources, or authority for personal or organizational gain" (Liu et al. 2019, p. 2). Pro-self unethical behavior partly overlaps with UPOB as both these constructs involve unethicality or the violation of hypernorms. However, there also exists a clear line of differentiation between these concepts. An unethical action carried out with the goal of benefiting *only oneself* is termed as pro-self unethical behavior. In contrast, an unethical action must, at least in part, intend to benefit the *organization* for qualifying to be recognized as UPOB. Seminal authors also note that "unethical behaviors conducted primarily with the intention of benefiting the self alone, and not the organization or its members, would not be considered unethical pro-organizational behavior" (Umphress and Bingham 2011, p. 623). Therefore, pro-self unethical behavior aims to benefit only the self, whereas UPOB aims to benefit (a) the organization alone, or (b) the organization as well as the self. Further, UPOB can be viewed as a subset of unethical decision-making because UPOB includes unethical actions that only intend to benefit the organization. In contrast, unethical decision-making covers both types of unethical activities—intended to help as well as harm the organization. In addition, unethical decision-making also includes unethical behavior that is carried out without any specific intention to help or harm. From the above discussion, it is evident that UPOB represents a unique phenomenon that cannot be fully explained by existing constructs. Hence, it has evolved as a distinct construct in the field of organizational behavior.

Method

A systematic review of unethical pro-organizational behavior literature was conducted instead of a traditional narrative review because systematic reviews are known to follow an objective, scientific, replicable, and transparent process that is exhaustive and minimizes bias (Parris and Peachey 2013; Tranfield et al. 2003). The protocol followed while conducting this systematic review (see Fig. 1) is in line with the standard procedures being practiced in the field (Hunter et al. 2019; Newman et al. 2017). A theory-based approach was adopted for conducting this review, and different elements explored in extant UPOB research were classified based on their underlying theoretical rationale. Doing so was necessary to enable future researchers to interpret the UPOB literature from a theoretical point of view.

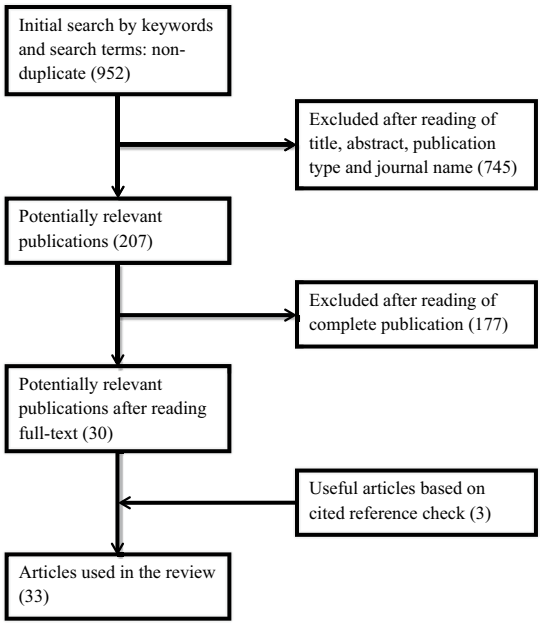


Fig. 1 Article search and selection process (Adapted from Hunter et al. 2019)

Inclusion and Exclusion Criteria

The following inclusion/exclusion criteria were established before undertaking the literature search. First, we only included studies that contained the keyword 'unethical pro-organizational behavior' in any part of the article. This filter was applied to eliminate articles focusing on similar yet distinguishable constructs like 'unethical behavior,' which were beyond the scope of the present review (see Treviño et al. 2014 for a review of the unethical behavior literature). Second, we restricted our search to articles published in top-tier journals to ensure that only rigorous and high-quality studies were incorporated into our review. Accordingly, our review was limited to studies published in any of Financial Times' Top 50 list of journals or A*/A category journals as per the ABDC 2019 journal quality list. Finally, we excluded articles that were not directly focused on the theoretical or empirical examination of unethical pro-organizational behavior and only touched upon the concept tangentially.

Literature Search

As prescribed by Short (2009), we searched a number of relevant scholarly outlets and electronic academic databases for journal articles (including Web of Science, EBSCO Host, Emerald, Sage, Springer, ProQuest, Wiley, JSTOR, Science Direct, Taylor and Francis, APA

PsycArticles and Google Scholar) using the keyword 'unethical pro-organizational behavior.' To increase inclusivity, we did not specify a start date. As shown in Fig. 1, the initial search by keyword across all twelve databases returned a total of 1278 research articles. Three hundred twenty-six duplicate publications were eliminated, and 952 articles were considered for the subsequent procedure. We followed a systematic process to clean these articles. First, we examined the titles, abstracts, publication types, and journal names of each of the retrieved articles. We found that 745 articles did not satisfy our inclusion criterion as they were not published in any of the Financial Times' Top 50 list of journals or A*/A category journals as per ABDC 2019 classification. Hence, they were excluded from our review. After the above filters were effectuated, we were left with 207 potentially relevant publications. Second, we read the full-text of each of these remaining articles and found that 177 papers were irrelevant to the study of unethical pro-organizational behavior as they only mentioned the concept superficially and did not examine it empirically or theoretically. Since these articles matched our exclusion criterion, they were dropped from our review, and we were left with 30 potentially relevant publications after reading the full-text. Third, we tried to ensure that relevant literature had not been overlooked in the previous search by manually examining the list of references associated with each of these 30 articles and the studies that had cited them. Accordingly, three manual additions were made to the dataset. Application of the aforementioned procedures resulted in the identification of 33 articles for inclusion in our review, 31 of which are empirical studies.

A Review of Unethical Pro-organizational Behavior Literature

In this section, we cover four major issues pertaining to extant UPOB research. First, we discuss how UPOB has been operationalized in the existing literature. Second, we deliberate over the antecedents of UPOB using a theory-based approach. Third, we note the boundary conditions that influence the impact of these antecedents on UPOB. Finally, we again use a theory-driven logic to present the consequences of UPOB.

Measuring UPOB

Our review identified 31 empirical studies conducted from 2010 to 2020, which have focused on investigating the phenomenon of UPOB in organizations (see Fig. 2 for the top-tier scholarly outlets where UPOB research has appeared). All of them adopted a quantitative research design wherein they conducted field surveys, field experiments, or laboratory experiments to enhance our understanding of UPOB. In our review, we note that broadly two types of measures have been utilized in the past research on UPOB. First, the most prominent measure of UPOB, which has generally been used in field survey studies, is the six-item self-report measure developed by Umphress et al. (2010). This measure captures an employee's self-reported willingness to engage in UPOB. Second, proxy variables have been typically utilized to operationalize UPOB in laboratory or field experiments. For instance, Baur et al. (2019) assessed pro-organizational dishonesty based on the number of instances of lying in a task where participants had the opportunity to lie to uphold the reputation of their respective organizations. Likewise, Chen et al. (2016) estimated UPOB based on employees'

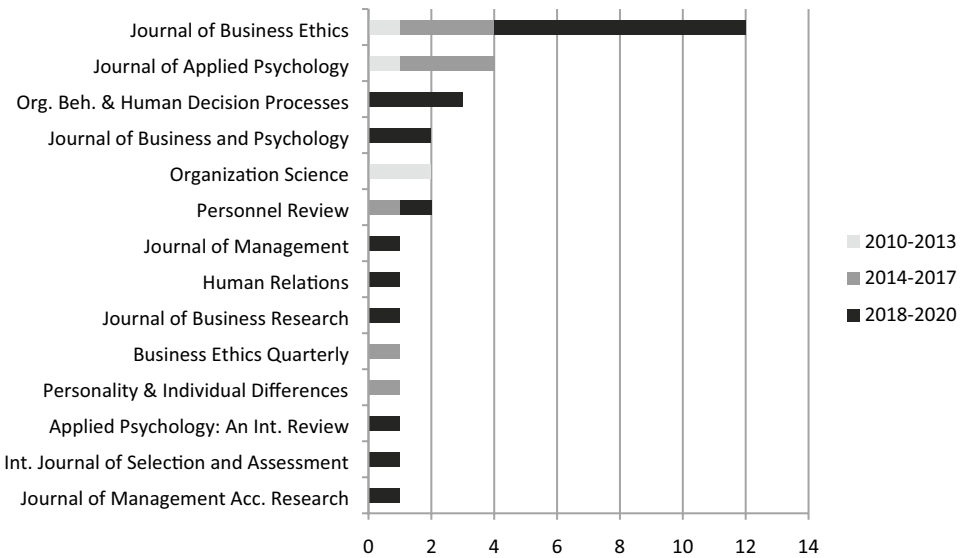


Fig. 2 Top-tier journals publishing UPOB research from 2010 to 2020

cheating behavior in an inter-organizational contest that carried awards for the organizations and not the winning employees. In another study, Chen et al. (2016) evaluated UPOB using participants' willingness to write false recommendation letters to get rid of a hopelessly poor-performing employee so that he (she) becomes a problem for the rival organization. Finally, Fehr et al. (2019) measured UPOB based on the respondents' willingness to permit the use of a banned chemical that is profitable for the organization but poses serious risks to the health of customers. Please see Table 1 for an extensive overview of the scholarly literature on UPOB. This table summarizes crucial details about the study sample, context, research design, theoretical perspectives, antecedents, boundary conditions, consequences, and key findings. The framework presented in Fig. 3 captures the extant research on UPOB into three areas of emphasis, namely, *antecedents*, *boundary conditions*, and *consequences*.

Antecedents of UPOB

In this subsection, we discuss the dominant theoretical perspectives that have been utilized in the extant literature to explain how UPOB occurs in organizations. Under each perspective, we identify the factors along with their ensuing psychological processes that have been found to give rise to UPOB in previous studies. Key factors that have been studied as independent variables and mediators in past research have been covered under this subsection.

Social Identity Perspective

The most compelling explanation for the occurrence of UPOB in organizations can be derived from the social identity theory (Tajfel and Turner 1979). According to this theory, individuals tend to define themselves based on membership in different social categories, and organizational identification develops when they perceive a sense of oneness, belongingness, and membership with their employing organizations (Ashforth and Mael 1989). Several scholars have put forth the view that identification serves as the psychological precursor to UPOB in the workplace. For instance, it has been argued that individuals high on organizational identification place the interests of their organization above the interests of those who would be harmed by their unethical actions (Umphress and Bingham 2011). The compelling desire to protect the organization pushes them to disregard ethical standards and perceive UPOB as a dutiful act, which is why employees who identify with their organizations are likely to engage in UPOB (Umphress and Bingham 2011). Likewise, transformational leaders develop and communicate an attractive vision, which allows their followers to feel psychologically intertwined with the fate of the organization and view the successes and failures of the organization as their own (Effelsberg et al. 2014). This sense of identification augments followers' willingness to engage in UPOB, even if doing so involves a deviation from ethical standards (Effelsberg et al. 2014). Further, the malevolent side of organizational identification has been unraveled, and it has been found that employees who identify with their organization believe that they are indispensable to the organization's functioning (Naseer et al. 2020). This elevated sense of importance makes them feel entitled to act on behalf of the organization and engage in UPOB (Naseer et al. 2020).

Social Exchange Perspective

Another dominant theoretical perspective that has been used by scholars to explain the occurrence of UPOB in organizations is extracted from the social exchange theory (Blau 1964; Emerson 1976). According to this theory, individuals try to return the favors they receive to build long-term social exchange relationships characterized by mutual trust and respect (Blau 1964; Emerson 1976). Several studies have relied on this theory and used social exchange-related variables to clarify how UPOB develops in organizations. For instance, it has been proffered that individuals involved in positive social exchange relationships with their employers view UPOB as a way to reciprocate the favorable treatment received from their supervisors and organizations (Umphress and Bingham 2011). Therefore, individuals who perceive positive social exchange relationships with their employers are likely to perform UPOB (Umphress and Bingham 2011).

Further, mutual investment employee–organization relationships, in which organizations provide high inducements to employees and expect equitable reciprocity in return, motivate employees to return the organization's favors by participation in UPOB (Wang et al. 2019). On a similar note, bottom-line mentality leaders provide straightforward and direct guidance to their followers that the key to obtaining rewards and success in the organization is the attainment of bottom-line objectives (Babalola et al. 2020). Followers perceive the provision of this valuable information as a form of social exchange, which fosters their feelings of obligation toward the organization's bottom-line and subsequent UPOB (Babalola et al. 2020). Finally, employees who perceive the presence of spiritual values within their work setting interpret UPOB as a means to reciprocate the positive social exchange relationships with their employers (Zhang 2020). Accordingly, two dimensions of workplace spirituality, namely, a sense of community with coworkers and an alignment with the organizational values, have been found to bring about UPOB among employees (Zhang 2020). A deep sense of connection among organizational members generates job satisfaction, which encourages collective-centered

Table 1 A summarized view of the unethical pro-organizational behavior literature

Authors (year)	Sample	Context	Research design	Theoretical perspectives	Antecedents	Boundary conditions	Consequences	Key findings
Umphress et al. (2010)	Study 1: 224 individuals called to court for jury duty Study 2: 148 individuals recruited through StudyResponse	The U.S	Empirical (Two field survey studies)	Social exchange, social identity	Organizational identification	Positive reciprocity beliefs	–	Organizational identification is positively related to UPOB when positive reciprocity beliefs are high
Umphress and Bingham (2011)	–	–	Conceptual	Social exchange, social identity	Organizational identification, positive social exchange relationships	Amoral culture, moral development, potential severity	Guilt, shame, cognitive dissonance	Organizational identification and positive social exchange relationships may lead to neutralization, which, in turn, may lead to UPOB
Miao et al. (2013)	239 full-time public sector employees	China	Empirical (One field survey study)	Social learning, social exchange	Ethical leadership	Identification with the supervisor	–	An inverted-u-shaped (curvilinear) relationship exists between supervisors' ethical leadership and subordinates' UPOB. The relationship is stronger for subordinates with high levels of identification with the supervisor
Vadera and Pratt (2013)	–	–	Conceptual	Self verification theory	Over-identification	–	–	Over-identification (i.e., high identification and low dis-identification with the organization) may lead to pro-organizational workplace crimes

Table 1 (continued)

Authors (year)	Sample	Context	Research design	Theoretical perspectives	Antecedents	Boundary conditions	Consequences	Key findings
Effelsberg et al. (2014)	Study 1: 290 employees from different professional backgrounds Study 2: 319 employees enrolled in a distance teaching university	Germany	Empirical (Two field survey studies)	Social identity	Transformational leadership	Personal disposition toward ethical behavior	–	Organizational identification fully mediates the positive relationship between supervisors' transformational leadership and subordinates' willingness to engage in UPOB. Personal disposition toward unethical behavior strengthens the link between organizational identification and UPOB
Effelsberg and Solga (2015)	112 managers and 900 direct reports in banking, insurance, and high-tech manufacturing sectors	Germany	Empirical (One field survey study)	TFL leadership	–	–	Followers' perceptions of TFL	No relationship was found between leaders' willingness to engage in UPOB and followers' perceptions of transformational leadership (TFL)
Graham et al. (2015)	74 employees recruited through Amazon Mechanical Turk	U.S	Empirical (One field experiment)	Regulatory focus	Inspirational and charismatic transformational leadership	Framing, Regulatory focus	–	Supervisors' charismatic and inspirational transformational leadership elicit higher levels of subordinates' UPOB than transactional leadership when supervisors use loss framing. The relationships hold for subordinates with low promotion focus

Table 1 (continued)

Authors (year)	Sample	Context	Research design	Theoretical perspectives	Antecedents	Boundary conditions	Consequences	Key findings
May et al. (2015)	149 full-time employees of an international food company	Korea	Empirical (One field survey study)	Theory of moral self	Moral identification	–	–	Moral identification is negatively associated with UPOB above and beyond the effects of organizational identification
Chen et al. (2016)	Study 1: 73 employees working for pharmacy stores Study 2: 240 employees of a retail company Study 3: 183 Amazon Turk workers	China and the U.S	Empirical (One field survey study and two field experiments)	Social cognitive	Organizational identification	Inter-organizational competition	–	Organizational identification is positively associated with UPOB. Moral disengagement mediates this relationship. The indirect relationship is stronger when the inter-organizational competition is high
Jiang et al. (2016)	2,417 employees and 196 managers of a theater chain	China	Empirical (One field survey study supplemented by objective data)	–	Ethical climate	–	Business performance	The ethical climate is negatively associated with unethical pro-organizational behavior, which, in turn, is negatively associated with business performance
Kong (2016)	128 employees recruited through StudyResponse	U.S	Empirical (One field survey study)	Self-determination	Work passion	Mindfulness	–	Mindfulness attenuates the relationship between obsessive passion and UPOB. Organizational identification mediates the relationship between obsessive passion and UPOB when mindfulness is low

Table 1 (continued)

Authors (year)	Sample	Context	Research design	Theoretical perspectives	Antecedents	Boundary conditions	Consequences	Key findings
Lawrence and Kacmar (2017)	Study 1: 107 architects, engineers, and accountants Study 2: 209 working adults	U.S	Empirical (Two field survey studies)	Self-regulation	Job insecurity	Adaptability, embeddedness	–	Emotional exhaustion mediates the positive relationship between job insecurity and UPOB. The indirect relationship between job insecurity and UPOB is stronger when adaptability is low, and embeddedness is high
Ghosh (2017)	346 executives from I.T., manufacturing, insurance, banking, and healthcare sectors	India	Empirical (One field survey study)	Social exchange	Job insecurity	Job embeddedness	–	Job insecurity and job embeddedness are positively associated with UPOB. Job embeddedness strengthens the relationship between job insecurity and UPOB
Castille et al. (2018)	170 full-time employees recruited through Amazon Mechanical Turk	U.S	Empirical (One field survey study)	Trait activation	Machiavellianism	Bottom-line mentality climate perceptions	–	Machiavellianism is positively associated with willingness to engage in UPOB regardless of the level of bottom-line mentality climate. Only the amoral manipulation facet of Machiavellianism accounts for variance in willingness to engage in UPOB

Table 1 (continued)

Authors (year)	Sample	Context	Research design	Theoretical perspectives	Antecedents	Boundary conditions	Consequences	Key findings
Mahlendorf et al. (2018)	253 respondents consisting of CFOs, controllers reporting directly to CFOs, and financial managers	Austria, Germany, Switzerland	Empirical (One field survey study and two follow-up surveys)	–	Incentive structures, organizational identification, proximity to retirement	–	–	Organizational identification and financial managers' incentives contingent on financial performance are positively associated with willingness to engage in UPOB. Proximity to retirement is negatively associated with the willingness to engage in UPOB
Matherne et al. (2018)	Study 1: 137 restaurant workers Study 2: 499 student members of Greek life	U.S	Empirical (Two field survey studies)	Self-determination	Individual moral identity centrality	Organizational moral identity centrality	–	Organizational moral identity centrality is negatively associated with unethical prosocial behaviors. Individual moral identity centrality is negatively associated with unethical prosocial behaviors only when organizational moral identity centrality is low
Baur et al. (2019)	Study 1: 1269 employees from different industries Study 2: 71 university students	Germany	Empirical (One field survey and one laboratory experiment)	Self-regulation	Depletion of self-regulatory resources	Organizational identification	–	Self-regulatory resource depletion is positively associated with pro-organizational dishonesty when organizational identification is high

Table 1 (continued)

Authors (year)	Sample	Context	Research design	Theoretical perspectives	Antecedents	Boundary conditions	Consequences	Key findings
Cheng et al. (2019)	426 salespersons and 120 sales team supervisors in three insurance companies	China	Empirical (One field survey study)	Social learning	High-level leader responsible leadership	High and low-level leader value congruence	–	Low-level leader responsible leadership mediates the negative relationship between high-level leader responsible leadership and UPOB. Leader-subordinate value congruence strengthens the indirect relationship between high-level responsible leadership and UPOB
Fehr et al. (2019)	Study 1: 176 supervisor-subordinate dyads Study 2: 297 participants recruited through MTurk Study 3: 281 participants through Qualtrics Panel	China and the U.S	Empirical (One field survey and two field experiments)	Social learning	Supervisors' UPOB	Supervisor moral decoupling	Supervisor-rated job performance	Employee perceptions of supervisors' moral decoupling strengthen the positive relationship between supervisors' UPOB and employees' UPOB. Employees' UPOB is positively associated with supervisors' evaluations of job performance when supervisors' moral decoupling is high

Table 1 (continued)

Authors (year)	Sample	Context	Research design	Theoretical perspectives	Antecedents	Boundary conditions	Consequences	Key findings
Grabowski et al. (2019)	425 employees working in different industries	Poland	Empirical (One field survey study)	–	Work ethic, organizational commitment	–	–	Four dimensions of work ethic (morality/ethics, delay of gratification, the centrality of work, and anti-leisure sentiment) are negatively associated with UPOB. The hard work dimension is positively associated with UPOB. Normative and affective dimensions of organizational commitment are positively associated with UPOB
Lee et al. (2019)	Study 1: 252 supervisor-subordinate dyads Study 2: 230 working adults of a Qualtrics Panel	China and the U.K	Empirical (Two field survey studies)	Social cognitive	Psychological entitlement	Organizational identification	–	Psychological entitlement is positively associated with UPOB, and organizational identification strengthens this relationship. Status striving and moral disengagement fully mediate the link between psychological entitlement and UPOB

Table 1 (continued)

Authors (year)	Sample	Context	Research design	Theoretical perspectives	Antecedents	Boundary conditions	Consequences	Key findings
Valle et al. (2019)	Study 1: 101 university students Study 2: 206 individuals recruited through uSamp	U.S	Empirical (One laboratory experiment and one field study)	Social cognitive, regulatory focus	Perceived organizational politics	Regulatory focus	–	Moral disengagement (M.D) mediates the positive relationship between perceptions of organizational politics (POP) and UPOB. Prevention focus strengthens the relationship between M.D and UPOB and the overall indirect relationship between POP and UPOB
Wang et al. (2019)	Study 1: 256 employees and 73 mid-level managers Study 2: 312 employees across 34 diverse firms	China	Empirical (Two field survey studies)	Social exchange	Mutual investment and over-investment EORs	Moral identity	–	Employee-perceived social exchange mediates the link between mutual investment employee–organization relationships and UPOB. Moral identity weakens the indirect relationship between mutual investment EOR and UPOB
Yu et al. (2019)	Studies 3–7: 173, 185, 288, 231, and 243 employees, respectively	U.S	Empirical (Five field studies)	–	Perceived power, perceived status	–	–	Perceived power is positively associated with UPOB. Perceived status is negatively associated with UPOB

Table 1 (continued)

Authors (year)	Sample	Context	Research design	Theoretical perspectives	Antecedents	Boundary conditions	Consequences	Key findings
Zhang (2019)	434 employees from different companies	China	Empirical (One field survey study)	Self-enhancement theory	Workplace ostracism	Value alignment	–	Workplace ostracism is positively related to UPOB when alignment with organizational values dimension of workplace spirituality is high
Babalola et al. (2020)	225 employees working in the Banking sector	West Africa	Empirical (One field survey study)	Social exchange	Supervisors' bottom-line mentality	Subordinate ambition	–	Supervisors' bottom-line mentality is positively associated with employees' felt obligation toward the bottom-line, which, in turn, is positively associated with employees' UPOB. Employee ambition strengthens the indirect relationship between supervisors' BLM and employees' UPOB
Graham et al. (2020)	Studies 1–3: 151 individuals,123 supervisor-subordinate dyads, and 182 individuals through MTurk	U.S	Empirical (Three field survey studies)	Moral maturation	Egoistic norms	Organization identification	–	Perceived ethicality of UPOB is positively associated with willingness to engage in UPOB. Egoistic norms are negatively associated with UPOB through ethical judgments. The indirect relationship is stronger when organizational identification is high

Table 1 (continued)

Authors (year)	Sample	Context	Research design	Theoretical perspectives	Antecedents	Boundary conditions	Consequences	Key findings
Lee et al. (2020)	224 full-time working adults recruited from an online research company	South Korea	Empirical (One field survey study)	Social identity, Self–affirmation	Organizational embeddedness	Ethical leadership	–	Status perceptions mediate the positive relationship between organizational embeddedness and UPOB. Ethical leadership weakens the indirect impact of organizational embeddedness on UPOB
Miao et al. (2020)	233 employees across 60 teams in government agencies	China	Empirical (One field survey study)	Social learning	Ethical leadership	–	–	Reflective moral attentiveness mediates the negative relationship between ethical leadership and UPOB
Naseer et al. (2020)	306 individuals working in academia, telecom, banking, healthcare, and legal sectors	Pakistan	Empirical (One field survey study)	Social identity	Organizational identification	Manipulative personality	–	Psychological entitlement mediates the positive relationship between organizational identification (O.I) and UPOB. Manipulative personality strengthens the indirect relationship between O.I and UPOB
Sheedy et al. (2020)	167, 319, and 191 employees (mostly non-managerial) in financial institutions	Australia	Empirical (Three field survey studies)	–	Risk climate	Unethical self-interest climate	–	Avoidance risk climate and unethical self-interest climate are both positively associated with potential UPOB

Table 1 (continued)

Authors (year)	Sample	Context	Research design	Theoretical perspectives	Antecedents	Boundary conditions	Consequences	Key findings
Tang et al. (2020)	Study 1: 91 employee-coworker dyads Study 2: 78 triads (focal employees, their coworkers, and customers)	China	Empirical (Two field studies using ESM)	Appraisal theories of emotion	–	Guilt proneness	Pride, guilt, OCB-O, OCB-C	Daily UPOB is positively associated with pride, which, in turn, is positively associated with OCB-O. Daily UPOB is positively associated with guilt, which, in turn, is positively associated with OCB-C. The link between daily UPOB and pride is stronger when guilt proneness is low
Zhang (2020)	458 employees working in diverse sectors	China	Empirical (One field survey study)	Social exchange	Workplace spirituality	–	–	Workplace spirituality dimensions (sense of community, alignment of values) are positively associated with job satisfaction, which is further positively associated with UPOB. Job satisfaction fully mediates the link between these two dimensions of workplace spirituality and UPOB

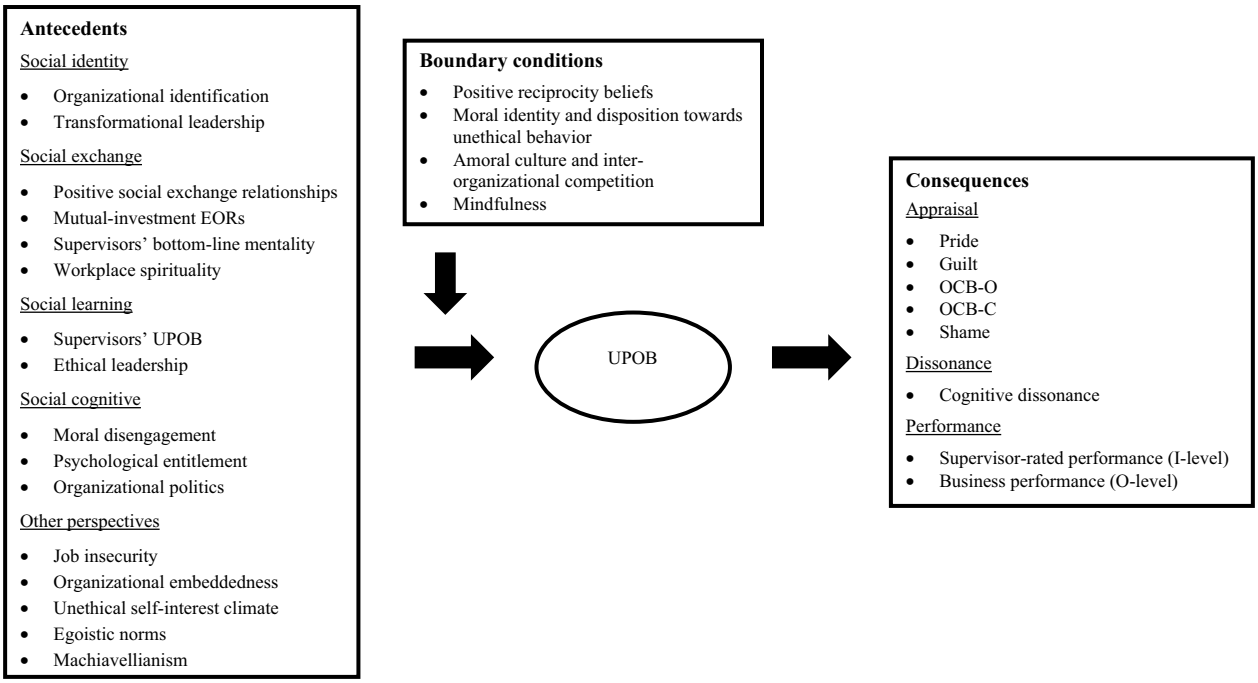


Fig. 3 A framework of unethical pro-organizational behavior research

actions like UPOB (Zhang 2020). Similarly, an alignment with organizational values fosters faith in the organization's integrity, which triggers job satisfaction and promotes actions like UPOB to preserve the organization's reputation (Zhang 2020).

Social Learning Perspective

The social learning theory has frequently been used as a theoretical base to clarify why UPOB occurs in work settings. According to this theory, individuals learn through rewards and punishments and/or by observing others (Bandura 1977). Several studies have relied on this theory to identify the factors that prompt employees to engage in UPOB. For instance, the cascading effect of supervisors' involvement in UPOB in stimulating UPOB among subordinates has been noted in past research (Fehr et al. 2019). Subordinates learn how to act in the work environment by observing the behavior of role models (supervisors) and, therefore, they mirror the UPOB of their supervisors (Fehr et al. 2019). However, the research on the role of ethical leadership in governing subordinates' UPOB has found mixed results. For example, Miao et al. (2020) drew entirely on social learning theory to argue in favor of a purely negative relationship between ethical leadership and UPOB. They reasoned that ethical leaders continually emphasize the importance of acting ethically, due to which their followers get primed to recognize and attend to ethical issues. Thus, the observation of ethical role models allows followers to become attentive to ethical dilemmas, and nudges them to reflect and control themselves from absentmindedly performing UPOB (Miao et al. 2020).

Miao et al. (2013), however, built on social learning theory as well as social exchange theory to provide evidence for an inverted-u-shaped relationship between supervisors' ethical leadership and subordinates' UPOB. They explained that ethical leaders treat their subordinates with fairness and care and that the followers of moderately ethical leaders would engage in UPOB to reciprocate this favorable treatment (social exchange). Also, they added that moderately ethical leaders have many important issues at hand (such as organizational interest) other than guarding ethics. Hence, followers of such leaders would learn to outweigh organizational interests over ethical standards by engaging in UPOB (social learning). However, followers of less ethical as well as highly ethical leaders would be unlikely to perform UPOB due to the following reasons. First, followers of highly ethical leaders would be conscious that such behavior would surely attract reprimand from the leader (social learning), which is why they would be wary of performing UPOB. Second, lesser ethical leaders do not treat their subordinates with fairness and care due to which low-quality exchange relationships are formed. Accordingly, followers would be unwilling to perform any activity (like UPOB) to advance the supervisor's or organization's interests (social exchange). Hence, the relationship between ethical leadership and UPOB is a complex one and depends upon the theoretical lens being used.

Social Cognitive Perspective

The social cognitive theory has been used in past research to unveil the antecedents of UPOB. According to this theory, unethical behavior occurs as a result of moral disengagement, which is a cognitive process that involves the deactivation of moral self-sanctions (Bandura et al. 1996). Moral disengagement, or "the set of mechanisms by which individuals circumvent moral standards in ways that strip morality from harmful behavior and their responsibility for it" (Valle et al. 2019, p. 176), has been established as a crucial cognitive process through which UPOB occurs. For instance, employees who identify with their organizations reframe UPOB as a righteous act that is necessary for the organization's overall good (Chen et al. 2016). Also, identification with the in-group reduces employees' perceived obligation for the welfare of out-groups, as a result of which highly identified employees do not hesitate to perform UPOB (Chen et al. 2016). Likewise, entitled individuals possess a stable yet possibly unfounded belief that they deserve more than others (Lee et al. 2019). Therefore, they view UPOB as an ego defense mechanism that enables them to preserve their inflated self-concepts, due to which employees high on psychological entitlement participate in UPOB (Lee et al. 2019). Further, employees in political work environments perceive that other organizational members are involved in political activities (like favoritism and manipulation of organization's policies) (Valle et al. 2019). Employees, therefore, deactivate their moral self-sanctions and take up UPOB as a viable strategy to survive such environments (Valle et al. 2019). Finally, neutralization or "the process by which the moral or ethical imperatives associated with an act are masked, overlooked, or dismissed," has been regarded as a cognitive process through which organizational identification and positive social exchange relationships translate into UPOB (Umphress and Bingham 2011, p. 626).

Other Perspectives

The seminal works on UPOB theorize that employees engage in UPOB primarily to benefit their organizations (Umphress et al. 2010; Umphress and Bingham 2011). However, an emerging stream of research suggests that participants of UPOB may be simultaneously driven by self as well as organizational interests. This body of research is consistent with the views of seminal authors who forwarded that "only unethical acts that are conducted, in part, to benefit the organization would constitute UPB" (Umphress et al. 2010, p. 770). They added that "unethical behaviors conducted primarily with the intention of benefiting the self alone, and not the organization or its members, would *not* be considered UPOB" (Umphress and Bingham 2011, p. 623). Therefore, it can be inferred that unethical actions that seek to simultaneously benefit the organization and the self also qualify to be termed as UPOB. Several studies have shed light on the role of these *dual motivations*, i.e., organizational as well as self-interests, in eliciting UPOB. For instance, job insecurity or employees' perception of a potential threat to the stability of their current jobs has been linked to UPOB (Ghosh 2017). Employees who fear the loss of their jobs may perform UPOB with the hope that doing so would allow them to gain acceptance in the organization and that the chances of their job loss would be reduced (Ghosh 2017). Likewise, employees who are highly embedded in their organizations are especially motivated to enhance their status in the eyes of other organizational members (Lee et al. 2020). They engage in UPOB as they believe that doing so would not only help the organization, but also increase their status and advance their self-interest (Lee et al. 2020). Further, self-interested unethical climates send signals that the organization permits employees to make self-interested decisions without any regard for consequences beyond the organization (Sheedy et al. 2020). Employees catch such signals and try to advance the organization's as well as their self-interest by engaging in UPOB (Sheedy et al. 2020). Similarly, egoistic norms, i.e., norms that signal the importance of maximizing self-interest and the interest of a small set of internal stakeholders, are known to elevate the perceptions of ethicality associated with UPOB and permit employees to engage in it (Graham et al. 2020). Finally, scholars have noted that the 'amoral manipulation' component of Machiavellianism, i.e., the willingness to overlook ethical standards in the pursuit of self-oriented outcomes, is a significant predictor of UPOB (Castille et al. 2018). Machiavellians believe that 'ends justify the means,' which is why they engage in UPOB when they perceive an overlap between their self-interest and the interests of their organization (Castille et al. 2018).

Boundary Conditions

In this subsection, we discuss the critical boundary conditions which heighten or suppress the impact of antecedents on UPOB. Factors that have frequently been studied as moderators in previous studies are covered under this subsection.

Positive Reciprocity Beliefs

Individuals differ in the extent to which they endorse reciprocity in social exchange relationships, and this difference is captured by positive reciprocity beliefs (Eisenberger et al. 2001). Individuals who strongly endorse positive reciprocity beliefs feel obligated to return favors to their exchange partners (Eisenberger et al. 2001). Accordingly, Umphress et al. (2010) noted the role of positive reciprocity beliefs as a catalyst in the precipitation of UPOB. Specifically, they

found that employees who identify with their organizations perform UPOB only if they feel obligated to return the beneficial treatment received from their organizations and believe that the organization would reciprocate their actions.

Moral Identity and Personal Disposition Toward Unethical Behavior

Moral identity refers to the extent to which individuals believe that morally relevant personality traits are crucial to their self-concepts (Reynolds and Ceranic 2007). Several studies have highlighted the role of moral identity in deterring the translation of antecedents into UPOB. For instance, Wang et al. (2019) noted that moral identity determines whether individuals in high-inducement employee–organization relationships (EORs) get involved in UPOB. Specifically, individuals in mutual investment EORs who are high on moral identity tend to be unwilling to sacrifice the interest of external stakeholders even if doing so benefits their organization because such behavior is inconsistent with their self-concepts (Wang et al. 2019). A similar construct, namely, personal disposition toward unethical behavior, also influences the effect of antecedents on UPOB. In specific, scholars have noted that employees who identify with their organizations tend to be more inclined to engage in UPOB if they possess an inherent tendency to act in unethical ways (Effelsberg et al. 2014).

Identification

While identification has largely been studied as an explanatory psychological process in the UPOB literature, some studies have also explored the role of identification as a boundary condition. For instance, scholars have noted the role of organizational identification in fueling the impact of self-regulatory resources depletion on pro-organizational dishonesty (Baur et al. 2019). Self-regulatory resources restrain individuals from acting in unethical ways. However, the depletion of these resources clears the way for participation in UPOB, particularly among employees who perceive a sense of oneness with their organizations (Baur et al. 2019). Likewise, scholars have noted the role of organizational identification in exacerbating the impact of egoistic norms on UPOB. Egoistic norms signaling the importance of self-interest or the interests of a narrow group of internal stakeholders are known to produce UPOB (Graham et al. 2020). However, these relationships are especially stronger for employees who identify with the organization because such employees internalize the organization's norms due to which they fail to consider hypernorms while making decisions (Graham et al. 2020).

Amoral Cultures and Inter-organizational Competition

In their conceptual work, Umphress and Bingham (2011) forwarded that amoral work cultures (where norms fail to encourage ethical conduct) become fertile grounds for employees with high organizational identification and positive social exchange relationships to perform UPOB. Further, the detrimental influence of inter-organizational competition in facilitating UPOB among employees has also been noted (Chen et al. 2016). When the organization's competition with rival firms intensifies, the stakes become higher, and employees who identify with the organization become even more willing to participate in UPOB to help their organization survive the competition (Chen et al. 2016).

Mindfulness

Mindfulness refers to a state of consciousness characterized by attention to internal and external phenomena in the present moment (Brown and Ryan 2003). Scholars have noted that mindfulness impedes employees with obsessive work passion from performing UPOB (Kong 2016). Specifically, mindfulness allows obsessively passionate employees to become conscious of their emotions and behavior, and offers them an opportunity to re-evaluate participation in unethical and risky behaviors like UPOB (Kong 2016).

Consequences of UPOB

In this subsection, we discuss the consequences of UPOB in work settings. Key factors that have been studied as dependent variables in previous studies have been covered under this subsection. We review these factors based on their underlying theoretical rationale.

Appraisal Perspective

According to the appraisal theory of emotions, emotions are generated when individuals compare their behavior with cognitive representations of themselves that are more stable and generally favorable (Roseman and Smith 2001). Drawing on this theory, scholars have noted that the *pro-organizational* component of UPOB is consistent with an employee's positive self-representation (due to the promotion of the organization's interests), which is why it results in feelings of pride (Tang et al. 2020). In contrast, the *unethical* component of UPOB is misaligned with employees' favorable view of themselves (due to violation of the customers' interests), which is why it results in feelings of guilt (Tang et al. 2020). These feelings of pride and guilt, in turn, result in compensatory behaviors such as OCB-O (directed toward the organization) and OCB-C (directed toward customers), respectively (Tang et al. 2020). These findings empirically

validate the contention of Umphress and Bingham (2011), who had similarly predicted that participants of UPOB would experience negative emotions, namely guilt (if a violation of personal ethical standards is perceived) and shame (if a departure from the idealized self is perceived). They added that these negative emotions would consequently restrain them from engaging in such acts in the future (Umphress and Bingham 2011).

Cognitive Dissonance Perspective

Cognitive dissonance theory suggests that individuals tend to experience a state of arousal when their behavior is inconsistent with their attitudes (Festinger 1957). Accordingly, Umphress and Bingham (2011) argued that participation in unethical and counter-attitudinal behaviors like UPOB creates a sense of arousal which gives rise to cognitive dissonance. They added that employees will attempt to resolve this unpleasant state of arousal using either of the two ways. First, they could use neutralization processes to eliminate the unethicality attached to their acts. Second, they could augment organizational identification or positive social relationships with the organization to rationalize their behavior.

Performance Perspective

Scholars have investigated the outcomes of UPOB from a performance appraisal standpoint. It has been noted that employees who engage in UPOB receive favorable job performance evaluations from their supervisors if supervisors believe that overall performance should be judged based on objective performance measures instead of morality (Fehr et al. 2019). In such cases, supervisors only pay heed to the *pro-organizational* component of subordinates' UPOB while evaluating them, and consider UPOB as a positive indicator of performance. Another study found that organizations where employees engage in UPOB perform poorly in terms of objective measures of business performance (Jiang et al. 2016). When customers realize that employees of a particular organization are violating their interests by performing UPOB, they diminish their loyalty toward those organizations, which translates into an overall decline in business performance (Jiang et al. 2016).

The above findings indicate that UPOB may result in positive as well as negative outcomes. The results of the aforementioned studies bolster the view of seminal authors who advocated that "although employees may try to help organizations by engaging in UPB, the final result of their actions may deviate from their intentions and may ultimately cause harm. Thus, UPB may ultimately produce unbeneficial and even destructive outcomes" (Umphress et al. 2010, p. 770). The conceptualization of UPOB focuses on the pro-organizational nature of the act, regardless of the ultimate consequences, which may be contingent upon a multitude of other situational factors.

Agenda for Future Research

In this section, we identify critical gaps in the existing body of knowledge on UPOB. We further propose possible pathways for addressing these gaps and advancing future research on UPOB.

UPOB in Teams

Most contemporary organizations use team-based structures to classify their employees. Since employees work closely with their team members, the team environment plays a pivotal role in shaping employees' attitudes and behaviors (Farmer et al. 2015). Despite the salience of team contexts in governing crucial employee outcomes, we find that no research so far has identified the team-level antecedents and consequences of UPOB. Given this deficiency in the literature, we urge future research to explore the team-level factors that may trigger employees to engage in UPOB. We additionally recommend future research to investigate how employees' involvement in UPOB influences other members of their teams.

We offer two pathways for addressing these gaps. First, we draw on social learning theory to propose that team members' participation in UPOB may be a plausible trigger for other employees within the same team to engage in UPOB. Social learning theory suggests that individuals learn about acceptable behaviors in work settings by observing and imitating others (Bandura 1977). Accordingly, we posit that UPOB is contagious such that employees who see their team members performing UPOB and getting rewarded for it would themselves develop an inclination toward performing UPOB. Our expectation is in line with past research, which reveals that unethical peer behavior translates into unethical behavior among observers due to vicarious learning (O'Fallon and Butterfield 2012). We further contend that the decision to emulate the UPOB of team members would be contingent upon individual (such as moral identity) as well as team-level characteristics (such as intra-team competition).

Second, we draw on the Attraction-Selection-Attrition (ASA) framework to explore the phenomenon of UPOB in teams. According to this framework, groups attract and subsequently select individuals whose aspirations, values and goals are consistent with those of the group (Cialdini et al. 2019; De Cooman et al. 2009). Contrarily, individuals whose values do not fit in with those of the group, tend to experience turnover (Cialdini et al. 2019; De Cooman et al. 2009). We speculate on the possibility that employees who engage

in (or are willing to engage in) UPOB may be attracted to, and selected for, teams that share the same perspective/beliefs. Consequently, team members with poor alignment may leave, and over time one could end up with teams with a higher likelihood of UPOB. Future research is encouraged to use vignette-based experimental research designs to examine these possibilities empirically.

The OCB-UPOB paradox

Although organizational citizenship behavior (i.e., OCB) and UPOB seem to be at the opposite ends of a continuum, we contend that there may be a certain degree of conceptual commonality between them. While OCB refers to "individual behavior that is discretionary, not directly or explicitly recognized by the formal reward system, and that in the aggregate promotes the effective functioning of the organization" (Organ 1988, p. 4), UPOB comprises of "actions that are intended to promote the effective functioning of the organization or its members (e.g., leaders) and violate core societal values, mores, laws, or standards of proper conduct" (Umphress and Bingham 2011, p. 622). We notice an overlap between the theorization of OCB and UPOB at two instances. First, both OCB and UPOB are voluntary behaviors discretionary in nature that are neither specified in the formal job descriptions/reward systems nor instructed by supervisors. Second, OCB and UPOB largely aim to promote the effective functioning of the organization though there may also be a simultaneous element of self-interest attached to both these behaviors (see Takeuchi et al. 2015 for impression management motives to perform OCB; and Castille et al. 2018 for alignment between self-interest and organizational interest to perform UPOB). However, the central point of distinction between both these behaviors is that UPOB violates hypernorms or globally held standards of ethical conduct, whereas OCB does not.

Despite a theoretical distinction between OCB and UPOB, we speculate that employees in practical settings may not always realize this distinction and may instead focus on the overlap between these behaviors. We throw light on a perilous possibility where employees may get confused between the two behaviors and may view UPOB as a special form of OCB. Our speculation is consistent with the views of Umphress and Bingham (2011), who similarly argued that employees who identify with their organizations experience a compelling desire to protect the organization which stimulates them to perceive UPOB as a dutiful act. We refer to this possibility as the *OCB-UPOB paradox*, wherein employees desirous of being good citizens and performing OCB unconsciously cross ethical boundaries and instead end up performing UPOB. It would be fruitful for future research to empirically examine the *OCB-UPOB paradox* and identify the boundary conditions under which the antecedents of OCB give rise to UPOB. One pathway for addressing this gap is to explore the role of individual characteristics (such as moral attentiveness, moral development, duty orientation, and the propensity to disengage morally) in moderating the relationships between OCB motives and UPOB. A starting point for this line of research may be to present a set of behaviors (containing examples of OCB and UPOB) and examine if and when respondents can distinguish between them sufficiently. It would further be interesting to study these behaviors longitudinally, and examine the intercepts and trajectories of OCB and UPOB to see if employees' intensified OCB over time may turn into UPOB, particularly in the presence of ethico-moral boundary conditions.

UPOB and Counterproductive Work Behaviors

It is established that UPOB as a form of prosocial behavior may harm the organization and other stakeholders. We additionally posit that not only is UPOB a dark behavior by itself, but it can additionally trigger other darker behaviors like counterproductive work behaviors. We draw on the moral licensing theory to support our contention. According to this theory, individuals who initially behave morally can later feel licensed to undertake unethical, immoral, and problematic behaviors (Blanken et al. 2015). Past research has also argued that the *pro-organizational* element of UPOB generates feelings of pride within employees. Integrating these theoretical perspectives, we propose that employees who undertake UPOB would feel proud of being able to help their organizations (albeit, in unethical ways), which can later license or entitle them to participate in counterproductive behaviors. This would especially be the case in organizations where behaviors like UPOB are condoned and rewarded. Our expectation is consistent with past studies which have noted that purely prosocial behaviors like OCB can lead to subsequent counterproductive behaviors (Klotz and Bolino 2013; Yam et al. 2017). Therefore, it might be interesting to examine whether partly dark and partly prosocial behaviors like UPOB can also inflame the precipitation of purely darker set of counterproductive behaviors, which not only flout social hypernorms but also organizational norms. Future research may consider conducting longitudinal or experiment-based studies to explore this possibility.

Conclusion

Unethical pro-organizational behavior has become a burning issue in the contemporary business landscape with organizations across the world losing billions of dollars in the form of settlements for their employees' UPOB. This theory-based review has developed a succinct yet comprehensive framework to highlight why, how, and when UPOB unfolds

in organizations. We hope that this review will sensitize practitioners about the severity of UPOB and caution them about the range of factors that have the potential to stimulate UPOB in work contexts. From a scholarly perspective, this review has summarized ten years of past research on UPOB and fostered an enhanced understanding of how this construct has evolved by drawing support from seminal theories. Additionally, this review has illuminated new pathways for future scholarship. We hope that this review will spark scholarly interest and accelerate research toward a more nuanced academic and managerial understanding of UPOB.

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Ethical Approval This is a review article. Hence, the study was granted exemption from requiring ethics approval.

Informed Consent This study does not involve human subjects. Therefore, informed consent was not required.

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